



Cultivating Faculty Support for Institutional Effectiveness Activities: Benchmarking best practices

JOHN F. WELSH & JEFF METCALF

To cite this article: JOHN F. WELSH & JEFF METCALF (2003) Cultivating Faculty Support for Institutional Effectiveness Activities: Benchmarking best practices, *Assessment & Evaluation in Higher Education*, 28:1, 33-45, DOI: [10.1080/02602930301682](https://doi.org/10.1080/02602930301682)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/02602930301682>



Published online: 27 May 2010.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 282



View related articles [↗](#)



Citing articles: 1 View citing articles [↗](#)

Cultivating Faculty Support for Institutional Effectiveness Activities: benchmarking best practices

JOHN F. WELSH, *University of Louisville, Louisville, Kentucky, USA*

JEFF METCALF, *Kentucky Christian College, Grayson, Kentucky, USA*

ABSTRACT *This study examines faculty perspectives on accreditation-driven institutional effectiveness activities in higher education and measures the impact of four predictor variables on faculty perceptions about the importance of institutional effectiveness activities. The findings suggest that three variables are critical to faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities: (i) institutional motivation for pursuing these activities; (ii) level of involvement or participation in institutional effectiveness activities; and (iii) definition of quality. The findings suggest some best practices that institutions can use to cultivate faculty support for institutional effectiveness initiatives.*

A New Challenge for Higher Education

The increased interest of students, governments, accrediting agencies, industry and the mass media in the performance, responsiveness and accountability of higher education since the late 1980s is a global phenomenon. F. King Alexander (2000) argues from a global perspective that accountability has a 'changing face', in that oversight agencies and higher education stakeholders in many nations are increasingly committed to the use of public policy tools to improve the alignment of the performance of higher education with the expectations of the public. Peter Ewell (1990, 1999) argues that a 'new accountability' or a 'culture of accountability' has enveloped higher education globally. The pressures on higher education to respond to the demands for improved documentation about the performance of colleges and universities appear every bit as strong as the demands for increased access to quality programmes and the challenges posed by increasingly constrained resources.

Response to the new accountability in the USA is the responsibility of not only individual colleges and universities, but of institutional accrediting agencies. Responsi-

bility for quality assurance in higher education in the USA has historically fallen on an extremely decentralised system of accrediting agencies, which largely monitored quality through institutional and programme compliance with a series of articulated regulations and standards for the learning environment. As the major conduit between institutions and the policy making community in the USA, institutional accrediting agencies helped institutionalise and operationalise the 'new accountability' in higher education through accreditation criteria and review processes that require institutions to collect, format, report and use information to improve the quality of their programmes and services. The activities associated with accountability and quality improvement promoted by the six institutional accrediting agencies are variously labelled 'quality assurance', 'quality enhancement' and 'institutional effectiveness'.

The term 'institutional effectiveness', the term adopted by the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools (SACS) in the USA, is interchangeable with other labels for data-driven, quality and strategic improvement processes (Southern Association of Colleges and Schools, 1998). SACS was one of the earliest higher education associations in the USA to adopt accreditation criteria that required institutional effectiveness activities. SACS adopted the term 'institutional effectiveness' in 1985 to require the collection of data about institutional performance that may be used to improve programmes and services. The infusion of institutional effectiveness statements into SACS's *Criteria for Accreditation* was intended to ensure that institutional effectiveness concepts permeate institutional self-management, an expectation that differs in terminology but not in purpose from the other five institutional accrediting agencies and many of the programme accrediting agencies in the USA. Institutional effectiveness typically encompasses activities such as student learning outcomes assessment, academic programme review, strategic planning, performance scorecards, performance benchmarking and quality measurement, each of which has numerous manifestations in academia. Despite variations in terminology, colleges and universities accredited by one of the six institutional accrediting agencies in the USA must demonstrate that they have designed and implemented acceptable processes of institutional effectiveness.

However, as colleges and universities attempt to respond to the demand for increased accountability they confront a disturbing paradox: even as institutional effectiveness activities become institutionalised features of the higher education landscape, campus support for them seems to be tenuous and shallow. Gaining the interest, commitment and support of institutional constituents is arguably the primary challenge colleges and universities face in designing and implementing institutional effectiveness activities. An institutional consensus on the importance of institutional effectiveness activities is fundamental to the successful integration of institutional effectiveness activities (Friedlander & McDougall, 1990; Morse & Santiago, 2000). Recent literature suggests an uninspiring record of success in cultivating campus support for institutional effectiveness in the USA; there is little evidence that institutional effectiveness activities have actually improved institutions, but there is evidence of barriers to faculty commitment and support for them (Ewell, 1989; Engelkemeyer, 1995; Gray & Banta, 1997). Nichols (1995) demonstrates that faculty resistance is the primary reason why institutional effectiveness initiatives fail, an observation supported by Birnbaum (2000).

The purpose of this article is to explore the sources of faculty support for the development and implementation of institutional effectiveness activities in higher education. Although the research is focused on faculty in the USA, it has global implications as institutions attempt to respond to the 'new accountability'. The research

attempts to address three important questions about faculty support for the implementation and development of institutional effectiveness activities in higher education. First, to what extent do faculty support institutional effectiveness activities? Second, are there any factors that help understand what affects faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities in higher education? Third, do the data suggest any institutional practices that might help cultivate faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities?

Research Methodology

The research questions in this study were addressed through a mailed questionnaire that was distributed to faculty who served on self-study steering committees, for whom contact information was available from the institution, during autumn 2000 at the 168 institutions that were reviewed by SACS between September 1998 and May 2000 for either initial accreditation or reaffirmation of accreditation.

This population was selected for three reasons. First, it was important to delineate a population of respondents from institutions accredited by one regional accrediting agency to ensure consistent, understandable and familiar terminology on the research instrument. Second, the selection of the time frame enabled the researchers to identify respondents who had recent experience with institutional effectiveness issues. Third, a review of standards and procedures of the six regional accrediting agencies in the USA reveals that each has specific accreditation criteria pertaining to institutional effectiveness, assessment and programme evaluation. The variation in terminology, however, makes a national or international study of faculty support for institutional effectiveness initiatives very difficult.

The population consisted of an actual respondent pool of 704 faculty. No sampling procedures were necessary since all potential faculty respondents were included. A total of 386 faculty responded to the survey, yielding a response rate of 54.8%, which surpasses an acceptable response rate of 50% and far surpassed the minimum number of acceptable respondents (182) established by a power analysis. Faculty respondents reported employment at their present institution for an average of 15.06 years and had worked in higher education for an average total of 18.99 years.

The survey instrument included five indices designed to address the three research questions. The first index is the dependent variable, Importance Attributed to Institutional Effectiveness Activities, and is the operational definition of faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities. This index is conceived as the dependent variable in the study. A review of research literature and commentary on institutional support for assessment and other data-based quality improvement strategies suggests that faculty support is affected by four predictor variables.

1. Perceived Definition of Quality Index. Since the mid 1980s, accrediting agencies, state coordinating boards and the higher education policy community have promoted an outcomes-based definition of quality (Chaffee & Scherr, 1992; Palomba & Banta, 1997). Institutional effectiveness increasingly refers to initiatives that are oriented toward the measurement and realization of an institution's progress toward fulfilling its mission or the fulfilment of expectations for student learning as measured by outcomes. Outcomes-based institutional effectiveness initiatives require extensive faculty participation and support. An outcomes-based approach cannot be pursued merely by documenting that the conditions necessary for quality instruction to take

place are present. Today, institutions must demonstrate the impact of instruction on student learning and that faculty members are actually using the results of these assessments to improve instruction. Faculty who support the outcomes-based conception of quality are more likely to support institutional effectiveness activities (Abraham-Ramirez, 1997; Clarke, 1997; Schilling & Schilling, 1998).

2. **Internal versus External Motivation Index.** There is a prevailing suspicion that institutional effectiveness has been forced on institutions by external entities, such as state governments, the federal government and accrediting agencies. External accountability, not internal improvement, appears to be the primary motivation for the implementation of institutional effectiveness activities. If campus constituents, including faculty, believe that institutional effectiveness activities are undertaken primarily to satisfy the standards of external groups, they will likely assign low levels of importance to them (Engelkemeyer, 1995). Seymour (1993) concurs but argues that internal motivators for institutional effectiveness activities are emerging and that these are likely to elevate internal institutional commitment to outcomes assessment and other data-based approaches to quality improvement. Internal motivators, such as quality improvement, may increase faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities.
3. **Depth of Implementation Index.** Perceptions of the importance of institutional effectiveness activities can be affected by the extent to which they have been integrated into the overall fabric of the institution (Birnbaum, 2000). Thomas (1997) found that faculty support for institutional effectiveness is enhanced by increased depth of the implementation of these activities. Clarke (1997) discovered that faculty are more likely to support institutional effectiveness activities if they believe that these activities will actually be implemented at their institution. Institutions frustrate support for institutional effectiveness activities by implementing shallow processes that are aimed at satisfying external mandates and not aimed at institutional transformation. Faculty who perceive the investment of minimal institutional effort in order to meet standards for institutional effectiveness may also attribute lower levels of importance to them.
4. **Reported Level of Involvement Index.** Institutional management processes may inhibit broad campus support for institutional effectiveness activities because they do not encourage participation and personal involvement of campus participants. The involvement of campus participants in any innovative process appears crucial to their receptivity to change and innovation (Richardson, 1988; Burgher, 1998). Level of involvement was identified as an important predictor of the degree to which institutional effectiveness programmes were successfully implemented in 2-year institutions in the USA (McClure, 1996; Thomas, 1997). It is not surprising that those who participate more intensely in institutional effectiveness activities are more likely to understand their role and express support for them. Institutions that seek to cultivate support for institutional effectiveness activities should seek to optimise faculty involvement in the process.

The indices, which included from nine to 18 Likert scale questions, were developed specifically for this research, although Thomas (1997) conducted research using two similar indices: depth of implementation and internal versus external motivation. The instrument provided faculty respondents with an opportunity to comment on open-ended questions about institutional effectiveness activities, including suggestions for improving their implementation.

Validity refers to how well the survey measures what it purports to measure (Litwin, 1995). Two means of ensuring content validity were employed in this research. First, the content validity of each index was established by a panel of six post-secondary education professionals who specialise in institutional effectiveness and serve as SACS evaluators. This method is patterned from the validation method used by Thomas (1997) in similar research on institutional effectiveness. Survey research literature also confirms the authenticity of this approach (Litwin, 1995; Weisber *et al.*, 1996). Litwin (1995, p. 35) explains the aim of this type of validation by stating that the assessment of content validity typically involves an organised review of the questionnaire contents to ensure that it includes everything it should and does not include anything it should not.

Panel members judged each item in the questionnaire and rated the degree to which it is appropriate as a measure of a dimension of the related variable. Although the final survey items were randomly distributed, panel members received a copy of the survey that grouped variables into indices. A brief description of the variable each index was designed to address was included. After rating individual items, panel members rated the overall adequacy of each index in addressing the related variable. Four point Likert scales were used for each item and the overall index rating, with space provided for written comments. Based on expert panel comments and rankings, the researchers made modifications to the proposed instrument. Changes made included a more focused conceptual definition of institutional effectiveness provided to respondents, clarification of several awkward questions and addition of two questions related to institutional mission areas (service and research) not previously included. The average expert evaluator ratings of each question were 'good' or 'excellent'. Also, each index was rated as 'good' or 'excellent' by each evaluator.

Reliability is a measure of how reproducible the survey instrument's data are. Since the survey instrument should measure five distinct variables through separate indices, the internal consistency reliability of the instrument is important. Litwin (1995, p. 21) notes that 'this is important because a group of items that purports to measure one variable should indeed be clearly focused on that variable'. Cronbach's coefficient α is a statistical procedure that indicates the degree to which different items correlate in their measurement of different aspects of the same variable (Litwin, 1995, p. 24). A threshold correlations coefficient, or r value, of around 0.70 is generally accepted to ensure the internal reliability of the instrument (Fink, 1995, p. 36; Litwin, 1995, p. 31).

The reliability of the instrument was established in the summer of 2000 through a pilot study of 69 higher educators at SACS institutions, who were excluded from the final sample and analysis. The response rate was 59%, with 41 responding. Internal reliability of the instrument was assessed using Cronbach's coefficient α tests. With the exception of the Definition of Quality Index, each coefficient α met or surpassed an r value of 0.70. The Definition of Quality Index had a 0.52 coefficient α and, because the coefficient α still indicates significant correlation among the subset of questions, warranted inclusion in the final research instrument.

Each of the five indices met, or was very near, the 0.70 threshold recommended by Litwin (1995). Cronbach's α scores ranged from a high of 0.93 to a low of 0.67. Each α score surpassed the 0.60 minimum criterion and all except one scale exceeded the 0.70 criterion goal established for this study. The coefficient α for each index was higher than the related coefficient α score from the pilot study. Significantly, the score for the Definition of Quality Index coefficient α rose to 0.67 from 0.52.

TABLE 1. Descriptive statistics and correlations of dependent and predictor variables

Variable	<i>n</i>	Mean	SD	SE	1	2	3	4	5
1. Importance of Institutional Effectiveness Index	303	3.89	0.723	4.16		0.722 ^a	0.664 ^a	0.735 ^a	0.657 ^a
2. Perceived Motivation Index	303	3.39	0.608	3.49			0.672 ^a	0.711 ^a	0.627 ^a
3. Perceived Depth of Implementation Index	303	3.78	0.763	3.77				0.757 ^a	0.683 ^a
4. Perceived Definition of Quality	303	3.57	0.584	3.57					0.602 ^a
5. Reported Level of Involvement	303	4.02	0.736	4.02					

^a*P* < 0.01.

Findings

The data were analysed using parametric statistical methods. The large size of the sample yielded a normal distribution compared with the universe of faculty at institutions accredited by SACS. Table 1 includes descriptive statistics for the first research question. The mean response for faculty was 3.89 on the five point scale, suggesting that the faculty included in the study attribute considerable importance to institutional effectiveness activities. An analysis of variance revealed no significant difference among faculty at different types of institutions on any of the five indices.

A correlation and hierarchical regression analysis addressed the second research question pertaining to the impact of the four predictor variables on perceived importance of institutional effectiveness activities. The correlation analysis summarised in Table 1 reveals that the predictor variables correlate significantly ($P < 0.01$) and strongly (correlation coefficients range from 0.602 to 0.757) with each other. The predictor variables also correlate significantly ($P < 0.01$) and strongly (correlation coefficients range from 0.657 to 0.735) with the dependent variable, perceived importance of institutional effectiveness activities.

The goal of the regression analysis was to determine the impact on administrative perceptions of the importance of institutional effectiveness activities by each of the predictor variables (Cohen & Cohen, 1983). The predictor variables are entered into the equation ordered by the strength of their relationship to the dependent variable. In this study, the predictor variables were entered in the following order: perceived definition of quality (0.735), perceived motivation (0.722), perceived depth of implementation (0.664) and reported level of involvement (0.657).

The regression analysis indicates that the predictor variables explain a considerable percent of the variance in the dependent variable ($R^2 = 0.654$, $\Delta F = 140.730$, $P < 0.01$). The data reveal that three of the predictor variables were significant predictors of the administrative perceptions of importance of institutional effectiveness activities: perceived motivation ($\beta = 0.404$), personal level of involvement ($\beta = 0.261$) and definition of quality ($\beta = 0.324$). However, depth of implementation did not serve as a significant predictor of faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities ($\beta = -0.061$).

Implications for Practice and Future Research

Without vigorous faculty support, institutional effectiveness is likely to be discarded as another failed management campaign (Birnbaum, 2000). Several faculty in the sample conveyed considerable suspicion about the value of institutional effectiveness activities. One commented, 'I think most faculty see institutional effectiveness as a detraction from

TABLE 2. Regression analysis of predictors of importance of institutional effectiveness activities

Variable	<i>B</i>	<i>SEB</i>	β
Perceived Motivation Index	0.375	0.050	0.404 ^a
Depth of Implementation Index	- 0.057	0.055	- 0.061
Definition of Quality Index	0.394	0.070	0.324 ^a
Level of Involvement Index	0.248	0.045	0.261 ^a

Adjusted $R^2 = 0.654$ ($n = 288$, $P < 0.01$).

^a $P < 0.01$.

their jobs and a burden on them in terms of time and energy'. However, others indicated that, with the support of a critical mass of campus constituents, including faculty, institutional effectiveness holds potential to become institutionalised in higher education. Faculty support may help ensure that they move beyond responses to external edicts and toward more routine and deeply implemented practices in higher education.

The data collected from this study provide an opportunity to suggest some 'best practices' which institutions may use as benchmarks to cultivate faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities. Benchmarking is a research and policy tool in the higher education community that promotes quality improvements by comparing institutional performance to a set of articulated practices. The philosophy underlying benchmarking is that learning from 'best practice cases' or 'best practice principles' is an effective way to improve the specific practices of any one organisation (Alstete, 1995). The higher education community can develop notions regarding best practices in the implementation of institutional effectiveness programmes by drawing from faculty perceptions related to their sense of the importance of institutional effectiveness activities.

The data from this study suggest three tentative best practices that might serve as benchmarks as institutions attempt to cultivate faculty support. First, faculty support appears to be dependent upon the cultivation of a sense across the institution that the *primary* motivation for the implementation of institutional effectiveness activities is to improve the institution's programmes and services. The regression analysis demonstrates the point that *institutional improvement* is a more compelling justification for institutional effectiveness than is *responsiveness to external mandates*. Institutional effectiveness activities serve many purposes, but institutional improvement appears from this sample to be a more potent source of faculty support than responsiveness to accreditation criteria or mandates from governmental entities. One respondent commented that administrators who seek to cultivate support should emphasise that institutional effectiveness is good for the institution 'irrespective of the external mandate from an accrediting agency'. One best practice the data suggest is that institutions are more likely to cultivate faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities if they promote the notion that the most important reason for implementing institutional effectiveness activities is institutional improvement.

Second, the data also indicate that faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities is likely to be increased by ensuring their personal involvement in institutional effectiveness activities. The regression analysis, and comments from faculty on their returned questionnaires, demonstrate that faculty are much more likely to support institutional effectiveness efforts if they and their colleagues lead, own and participate in the process. One respondent said, 'for faculty to commit themselves to institutional effectiveness, they will really have to own it'. A second best practice the data suggest is that institutions are more likely to cultivate faculty support if they *optimise* the involvement of faculty in the design, development and implementation of institutional effectiveness activities. It is important to note that the emergent outcomes-based approach to institutional effectiveness requires considerable changes in institutional practice, planning and research offices that may have important roles in the collection and dissemination of data, but they cannot 'close the loop' by implementing changes suggested by the information; this requires that faculty participate and implement improvements in their everyday work.

Third, the faculty in this study reported that they are more likely to support institutional effectiveness activities if they also believe that the *outcomes* perspective is

the preferred view of quality. The regression analysis clearly indicates that outcomes-oriented faculty were much stronger supporters of institutional effectiveness activities than the faculty who adhered to traditional notions of academic quality. One respondent indicated that faculty support is based upon the 'presentation of real results arising from instruction and efforts to improve'. Thus, a third best practice suggested by the faculty included in this sample is that institutions are more likely to cultivate faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities if they promote an outcomes-oriented perspective on quality.

Although not included in the regression analysis, comments from many respondents on the questionnaire indicate that faculty strongly believe that effective communication of the process and results is a critical feature of developing support for institutional effectiveness activities. One commented that 'to figure out how to implement institutional effectiveness, before implementing, we must learn and teach faculty and staff about it'. Respondents provided numerous examples of communications strategies that include written memos to all faculty and staff, annual reports, interactive web-based presentations of the data and their use and forums open to all employees in which the data and improvement processes are developed and discussed.

These findings may help institutions and academic units develop a deeper consensus about the design and implementation of institutional effectiveness or other data-driven improvement programmes. Faculty involvement and support are critical to successful implementation. Administrators should not expect spontaneous support for these programmes from faculty. Administrators may hold responsibility for institutional effectiveness processes, but they must cultivate faculty interest and support, if the processes are to have any appreciable impact on the institution. The observations from these commentaries and research suggest that attention to such things as clearly defining roles of participants, providing resources to learn and implement institutional effectiveness activities and rewards and recognition are critical in generating faculty support. This study contributes this accumulating body of knowledge by discovering that (i) personal involvement, (ii) an outcomes orientation and (iii) a primary motivation to improve the institution are important drivers of faculty support and, thereby, provide empirical confirmation of arguments that appear in Ewell (1989), Banta (1993), Gray and Banta (1997) and Palomba and Banta (1999) on the cultivation of institutional support for assessment.

There are limitations in this study that suggest the importance of future studies with broader samples and attention to the development of the indices. First, the fact that this study looked only at faculty who were involved in SACS self-study processes raises a question about the extent to which this sample represents faculty nationally or internationally. Faculty drawn from a SACS sample may have altogether different attitudes toward the importance and implementation of institutional effectiveness activities than administrators from other regional accrediting groups. However, the differences in terminology and accreditation criteria across accrediting groups inhibit the creation of research instruments that can be applied on a broader scale. Second, the faculty in this sample participated on SACS self-study committees. It is possible that faculty who serve on such committees have more positive predispositions toward institutional effectiveness activities, just as they have a different knowledge base, from those faculty who have not participated on such committees.

What is perhaps more significant is that this is the first empirical study on the cultivation of faculty support for institutional effectiveness activities that identifies and measures the four independent variables we identify in this study. Thomas (1997) is

similar in some respects, but uses only two of the same indices and defines them differently. Additionally, the sample in this study represents a broader array of institutions. Almost all of the other literature on this topic is polemical or anecdotal. While much can be learned from this other literature we believe that our study breaks new ground because (i) it is an empirical test of assumptions or arguments found in other articles and (ii) discovers that faculty support is mediated by the four independent variables included in the study. Future studies, however, will need to refine the indicators included in this research project. The indices included in this study are new and will need repeated use and refinement to develop more confidence in their validity and reliability.

External stakeholders, such as public oversight entities, may be somewhat encouraged to learn from this study that faculty tend to perceive institutional effectiveness activities as important. If faculty do not recognise its importance for institutional improvement and self-knowledge, it is unlikely that institutional effectiveness initiatives will succeed in improving either the performance or stature of higher education in any enduring way. Although several faculty in the survey indicated that they were not convinced that institutional effectiveness activities are appropriate methods for improving the quality of their institutions, one of the faculty respondents summarised the feelings of many others by suggesting that the implementation of institutional effectiveness activities may be an ongoing task that is dependent upon institutional cultivation of support for them: 'It is very important that we work to communicate the importance of institutional effectiveness. We discovered that the greatest asset of institutional effectiveness is that we have become proactive in the our approach to the mission of our college and its business'.

Notes on Contributors

JOHN F. WELSH is Acting Dean and Associate Professor of Education at the University of Louisville. He teaches courses in higher education finance, administration and organization and college teaching. His current research focuses on assessment and information systems in higher education. *Correspondence:* Office of the Dean, College of Education and Human Development, University of Louisville, Louisville, Kentucky 40292, USA. Tel: +1 502.852.6411. Fax: +1 502.852.0726. E-mail: john.welsh@louisville.edu

JEFFREY METCALF is Vice President for Planning and Assessment at Kentucky Christian College in Grayson, Kentucky. He recently completed a doctorate in education at the University of Louisville. His current research focuses on faculty and administrative support for institutional effectiveness in higher education.

REFERENCES

- ABRAHAM-RAMIREZ, H. D. (1997) Sources of influence on faculty members' receptivity to continuous quality improvement initiatives, doctoral dissertation, Pennsylvania State University, University Park, PA.
- ALEXANDER, F. K. (2000) The changing face of accountability: monitoring and assessing institutional performance, *The Journal of Higher Education*, 71 (4), pp. 411–431.
- ALSTETE, J. (1995) *Benchmarking in Higher Education: adapting best practices to improve quality*, ASHE-ERIC Higher Education Report no. 5 (Washington DC, George Washington University).
- BANTA, T. W. (1993) *Making a Difference: outcomes of a decade of assessment in higher education* (San Francisco, CA, Jossey-Bass).
- BIRNBAUM, R. (2000) *Management Fads in Higher Education* (San Francisco, CA, Jossey-Bass).

- BURGHHER, R. L. (1998) The perceptions of support for innovation in mid-western liberal arts colleges, doctoral dissertation, University of Iowa, Iowa City, IA.
- CHAFFEE, E. & SHERR, L. (1992) *Quality: transforming postsecondary education*, ASHE-ERIC Higher Education Report no. 3 (Washington DC, ERIC Clearinghouse on Higher Education).
- CLARKE, J. S. (1997) Personal and organizational structure correlates of receptivity and resistance to change and effectiveness in institutions of higher education, doctoral dissertation, Louisiana State University and Agricultural and Mechanical College, Baton Rouge, LA.
- COHEN, J. & COHEN, P. (1983) *Applied Multiple Regression/Correlation Analysis for the Behavioral Sciences* (Hillsdale, NJ, Lawrence Erlbaum Associates).
- ENGELKEMEYER, S. W. (1995) Engaging faculty in continuous improvement and change initiatives, in: J. S. SIMS & R. R. SIMS (Eds) *Total Quality Management in Higher Education: is it working? Why or why not?* (Westport, CT, Praeger).
- EWELL, P. T. (1989) Institutional characteristics and faculty/administrator perceptions of outcomes: an exploratory analysis, *Research in Higher Education*, 30 (2), pp. 13–36.
- EWELL, P. T. (1990) *Assessment and the 'New Accountability': a challenge for higher education's leadership* (Denver, CO, Education Commission of the States).
- EWELL, P. T. (1999) Assessment of higher education quality: promise and politics, in: S. J. MESSICK (Ed.) *Assessment in Higher Education: issues of access, quality, student development, and public policy* (Mahwah, NJ, Lawrence Erlbaum Associates).
- FINK, A. (1995) *How to Analyze Survey Data* (Thousand Oaks, CA, Sage).
- FRIELANDER, J. & MACDOUGALL, P. R. (1990) Responding to mandates for institutional effectiveness, *New Directions for Community Colleges*, 72 (4), pp. 93–100.
- GRAY, P. J. & BANTA, T. W. (Eds) (1997) *The Campus-level Impact of Assessment: progress, problems and possibilities*, New Directions for Higher Education, No. 100 (San Francisco, CA, Jossey-Bass).
- LITWIN, M. S. (1995) *How to Measure Survey Reliability and Validity* (Thousand Oaks, CA, Sage).
- MCCLURE, T. R., JR. (1996) A study of the impact of externally mandated institutional effectiveness and assessment activities on South Carolina technical colleges as perceived by technical college personnel in leadership roles, doctoral dissertation, University of South Carolina, SC.
- MORSE, J. A. & SANTIAGO, G. (2000) Accreditation and faculty: working together, *Academe*, 86, pp. 30–34.
- NICHOLS, J. (1995) *A Practitioners Handbook for Institutional Effectiveness and Student Outcomes Assessment Implementation* (New York, Agathon Press).
- PALOMBA, C. & BANTA, T. W. (1999) *Assessment Essentials: planning, implementing, and improving assessment in higher education* (San Francisco, CA, Jossey-Bass).
- RICHARDSON, R. C. (1988) Improving effectiveness through strategic planning, *Community College Review*, 15 (4), pp. 28–34.
- SCHILLING, K. M. & SCHILLING, K. L. (1998) *Proclaiming and Sustaining Excellence: assessment as a faculty role*, ASHE-ERIC Higher Education Report no. 26 (3) (Washington DC, George Washington University).
- SEYMOUR, D. (1993) *On Q: causing quality in higher education* (New York, MacMillan).
- SOUTHERN ASSOCIATION OF COLLEGES AND SCHOOLS COMMISSION ON COLLEGES (1998) *Criteria for Accreditation* (Decatur, GA, Southern Association of Colleges and Schools).
- THOMAS, J. P. (1997) Innovation conditions and processes used in the adoption of institutional effectiveness in two-year colleges of the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Accreditation Region, doctoral dissertation, North Carolina State University, Raleigh, NC.
- WEISBERG, H. F., KROSNICK, J. A. & BOWEN, B. D. (1996) *An Introduction to Survey Research, Polling and Data Analysis* (Thousand Oaks, CA, Sage).

Appendix

Survey Items and Design of Indices

Importance of Institutional Effectiveness Index

1. IE plays an important role in improving our institution.
2. IE will be an important component of regional accreditation well into the future.
3. Efforts to evaluate the effectiveness of our institution are worthwhile.
4. IE activities are not an important component of my job responsibilities.
5. IE is primarily the responsibility of administrators on our campus.
6. IE is a fad that will likely be replaced by another area of emphasis.
7. IE at our institution is, or would be, strengthened by active participation by faculty members.
8. Resources dedicated to IE activities are investments in the long-term health of our institution.
9. Documenting IE should be an integral element to any regional or department-specific accreditation criteria.

Internal versus External Motivation Index

1. We mainly conduct IE activities because of accreditation requirements.
2. We mainly conduct IE activities to maintain performance-based funding.
3. Improvement of programs and services is the primary motivation for IE on our campus.
4. If there were no outside requirements or mandates, our commitment to IE activities would probably diminish.
5. Evaluating the effectiveness of our institution is a natural extension of the ideals of investigation and inquiry within the academy.
6. IE does little to affect the true quality of our institution.
7. Change happens so slowly at our institution that it's hard to specify what changes are based on particular evaluations.
8. The results of our IE process seem to be more important to outside stakeholders than to our campus community.
9. Our institution offers such quality that IE initiatives can do little to improve it.

Depth of Implementation Index

1. Our institution has a systematic process of IE.
2. Departmental IE goals are generally known by individuals in the departments.
3. IE is a continual process at our institution.
4. Faculty, staff, and administrators are actively involved in our IE program.
5. IE activities throughout our institution are not very interrelated.
6. Our IE process has been developed to 'fit' our institution.
7. Expected educational results are clearly defined at our institution.
8. Our institution is committed to allocating resources to remedy areas of weakness found through the IE process.
9. The benefits of our IE process are clearly not worth the resources we invest in the process.
10. Procedures for assessing goal attainment are clearly stated at our institution.
11. Administrative responsibility for institutional research has been assigned at our institution.
12. Our institutional mission is central to our planning process.
13. Specific changes at our institution have occurred because of evaluation results.
14. Institutional research is an integral part of our institution's IE process.
15. All areas of our institution evaluate effectiveness (e.g. student learning, research, and service).
16. A variety of quantitative and qualitative assessment techniques are used to evaluate educational goals at our institution.
17. IE processes do little to help our institution fulfill its mission.
18. Our institution dedicates sufficient resources to IE activities.

Definition of Quality Index

1. The opinions of students (including alumni) are important in determining the quality of education at my institution.

2. Students at my institution are regarded as customers.
3. Quality at my institution is defined by how well we achieve our mission.
4. Institutional resources (i.e. buildings, volumes in library, faculty with superior credentials, endowments, reputation, price students are willing to pay, technology, etc.) are adequate indicators of our institutional quality.
5. Improving quality at my institution requires collaboration between faculty, staff, and administrators.
6. Measuring our institutional goals does not necessarily measure our educational quality.
7. The IE process at my institution is important in determining our overall quality.
8. Multiple stakeholders (e.g. employers, students, public representatives) are involved in determining what counts as 'quality' in our institution.

Level of Involvement Index

1. I have participated in a review of my institution's mission statement.
2. I am highly involved in IE activities at my institution.
3. I have participated in defining specific goals for my area.
4. I have helped formulate assessment techniques to measure progress toward area goals.
5. I am not familiar with the IE plan for my area.
6. I have engaged in specific assessment exercises to aid in my institution's IE activities.
7. I have not made improvements as a result of specific assessment results from our IE activities.
8. I am not personally aware of benefits of IE activities.
9. I use the results of IE activities to support budget requests.

